



The Budget Line Was Already There: A Survey of Master of Priority Studies Alumni on Capstone Panel Rank and Recommendation Implementation

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doi:10.5555/slop.aaxt6q

Abstract. The capstone panel of the Master of Priority Studies scores every graduating cohort's client-facing recommendation on a five-tier priority scale at the terminal pitch session, on the working assumption that a higher rank marks a recommendation more likely to be carried through. We test that assumption with a survey of alumni from six capstone cohorts ($n = 151$ respondents of 224 eligible, 67% response rate), matching each respondent's self-reported implementation outcome against the panel's contemporaneous priority tier and against whether the sponsoring unit already carried a matching budget line at pitch time. Panel tier does not reliably predict implementation ($\chi^2(4) = 0.9, p = 0.92$); the pre-existing budget line does, overwhelmingly (78% of recommendations pitched against an existing line saw some implementation, against 24% without one; OR = 11.6, 95% CI [5.4, 24.9], $p < .001$), and the two predictors move independently of one another once both are entered in the same model. A curriculum change intended to help students target proposals toward already-funded lines left the size of this gap unchanged before and after its introduction. We suggest the capstone panel's rank functions as a credentialing signal to the graduating student rather than a forecast of what the sponsoring unit will actually do with the recommendation, and discuss what this implies for priority-setting exercises that assume their own ranking predicts uptake.

Introduction

The Master of Priority Studies closes each cohort with a capstone pitch: a graduating student presents a client-facing recommendation, developed over a term with a sponsoring University unit, to a four-member interdisciplinary panel drawn from across the School of Emergent Priorities. The panel scores each pitch on a five-tier priority scale — from Tier 1, the lowest standing rank the format awards, to Tier 5, reserved for recommendations the panel judges most urgent — and the tier is recorded in the program's own archive as the pitch's formal outcome. Graduating students, sponsoring units, and the program itself all treat the tier as more than a grade: it is routinely described, in program materials and in exit interviews, as the panel's best estimate of how likely the recommendation is to actually happen.

That description embeds an empirical claim that, to our knowledge, the program has never tested against what its own alumni go on to observe. A panel's priority tier is assigned from a fixed vantage point — a single pitch session, a fixed rubric, forty minutes of questions — while implementation unfolds afterward, inside the sponsoring unit, on a timeline and under constraints the panel cannot fully see from the pitch room. The research-utilization literature has long distinguished the moment a recommendation is judged worthy from the moment, if any, it is acted on [1], [2], and implementation-science frameworks built to explain that gap treat the availability of resources already committed to a problem as one of the most consistent determinants of whether a change actually lands [3], [4]. A capstone program that scores pitches on priority alone, without asking what independently

predicts implementation, is well positioned to find out whether its own scoring instrument is measuring the thing it claims to measure.

We surveyed alumni from six capstone cohorts of the Master of Priority Studies, matching self-reported implementation outcomes against two predictors recorded independently at pitch time: the panel's priority tier, and whether the sponsoring unit's budget already carried a line item the recommendation could be actioned under without new appropriation. Our contributions are threefold:

- we show that panel priority tier, the program's own headline scoring instrument, does not reliably predict whether a recommendation is implemented, at least across the cohorts surveyed;
- we show that a pre-existing matching budget line predicts implementation overwhelmingly, and does so independently of panel tier;
- we show that a curriculum change aimed at helping students target their pitches toward already-funded lines left the size of the implementation gap between funded and unfunded proposals unchanged, suggesting the effect is structural rather than a skill the program can straightforwardly teach around.

Related work

Research-utilization scholarship has repeatedly distinguished the act of judging a recommendation from the act of acting on it, and has catalogued several distinct modes — instrumental, conceptual, symbolic — in which a piece of guidance can be said to be “used” without any of them guaranteeing implementation in the sense a sponsor would recognise [1]. Caplan's two-communities account attributes part of the gap to a structural mismatch between the people who produce a recommendation and the people who would have to act on it, who typically answer to different incentives and different clocks [2]; more recent systematic reviews of what actually predicts evidence uptake by policymakers find organisational and resource factors doing at least as much work as the evidence's own apparent quality [5], a pattern echoed in cross-jurisdiction studies of which characteristics of research findings predict their uptake in practice [6].

Implementation-science frameworks built to formalise this gap converge on resource avail-

ability as a load-bearing determinant largely orthogonal to how favourably a recommendation was initially received: the Consolidated Framework for Implementation Research names available resources as a distinct implementation determinant sitting alongside evidence strength [3], the Exploration-Preparation-Implementation-Sustainment model separates outer-context funding conditions from the inner-context appraisal of an innovation's merit [7], and reviews of diffusion in service organisations likewise find that an innovation's fit with existing organisational resources shapes adoption independently of its assessed quality [8]. Klein and Sorra's account of implementation climate makes the mechanism explicit: an organisation implements what its existing resources make low-friction to implement, more reliably than it implements what it has merely rated highly [4]. Proctor and colleagues' implementation-outcomes taxonomy separately tracks feasibility and cost from the antecedent judgement of an intervention's value, treating them as analytically distinct outcomes precisely because one does not follow from the other [9], and evaluation scholarship on sustainability planning finds funding continuity a more consistent predictor of an initiative's survival than the strength of its original evaluation [10]. On the policy side, evidence-based policymaking is understood to run on different rails from evidence-based medicine precisely because a policy recommendation's uptake depends on budgetary and political sequencing that no clinical-trial analogy captures [11], [12]; classical accounts of budgeting as an incremental process built outward from an existing base, rather than a comprehensive re-ranking of all competing priorities each cycle, offer one structural reason why a recommendation without a base to build from starts at a disadvantage regardless of how it was ranked [13], [14].

A parallel literature on panels that rank proposals under uncertainty supplies the sharpest analogy to our null result: grant-review panels' percentile scores have been found only weakly predictive of a funded project's eventual productivity [15], and panels asked to select the strongest proposals from a pool show limited ability to distinguish outcomes that will separate downstream [16]. The capstone-education literature has separately documented that client agencies value capstone projects for reasons

that do not always track the recommendation's assessed quality, including relationship-building and low-cost external review [17], which is consistent with a capstone panel functioning partly as a credentialing exercise for the student rather than a forecast of the recommendation's institutional fate.

Method

Setting and sample. We surveyed alumni of the Master of Priority Studies from six consecutive capstone cohorts, contacting all 224 alumni for whom the program held current contact details. We received 151 responses (67% response rate). Each response was matched, using the respondent's capstone identifier, against the program's own pitch-session archive, which independently records the panel's priority tier (1–5) and whether the sponsoring unit's published operating budget already carried a matching line item at the time of the pitch, coded by program administrators from the unit's budget documents rather than from the pitch itself.

Outcome measure. Respondents self-reported their capstone recommendation's implementation status as of the survey date, at least eighteen months after their capstone, in three categories: implemented in full, partially implemented, and not implemented. We report implementation both as the strict “implemented in full” category and, where noted, as a broader “any implementation” category combining full and partial.

Analysis. We tested the panel-tier relationship with a chi-square test of independence between tier and full implementation, and modelled full implementation jointly against tier and budget-line status with a logistic regression:

$$\text{logit}(P(\text{implemented})) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{ tier} + \beta_2 \text{ budget} + \varepsilon$$

where tier is the panel's five-level priority rank at pitch and budget is a binary indicator for whether a matching budget line existed at pitch time, entered together so that each coefficient is estimated net of the other.

Ablation. The program introduced a Budget Literacy module into the capstone curriculum ahead of the fourth surveyed cohort, intended to help students identify a sponsoring unit's existing budget lines before finalising a pitch. We repeat the budget-line regression separately for the three cohorts before the module and the

three after, and test the tier-by-era and budget-by-era interactions, to check whether the module changed the size of either effect rather than merely the rate at which students happened to target funded lines.

Results

Figure 1 plots the share of recommendations implemented, against not implemented, by the panel's priority tier at pitch. The two shares sit within a few points of each other at every tier; a chi-square test finds no reliable association between tier and implementation ($\chi^2(4) = 0.9$, $p = 0.92$, $N = 151$). Tier 3 recommendations, the scale's mid-point, show the highest raw implementation share (35%) and Tier 1, its lowest rank, the lowest (28%), but the ordering across the remaining tiers is not monotonic, and none of the pairwise tier differences reaches significance. On this measure, the capstone panel's headline scoring instrument carries no detectable forecasting value for the recommendation's eventual fate.

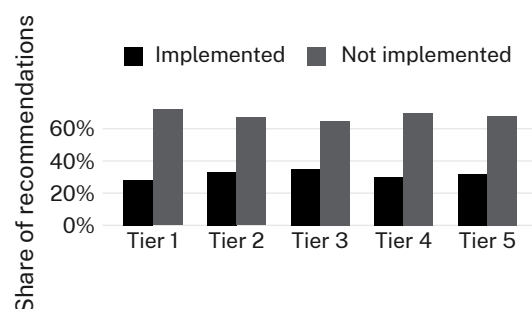


Figure 1: Share of capstone recommendations implemented versus not implemented, by panel priority tier at pitch ($N = 151$). The shares are flat across all five tiers.

A pre-existing budget line tells a different story. Figure 2 breaks implementation outcome down by whether the sponsoring unit already carried a matching budget line at pitch time. Recommendations pitched against an existing line saw some implementation — full or partial — 78% of the time (58% full, 20% partial); recommendations with no matching line saw some implementation only 24% of the time (9% full, 15% partial). Entered jointly in the logistic model, budget-line status predicts full implementation reliably ($OR = 11.6$, 95% CI [5.4, 24.9], $p < .001$), while panel tier, in the same model, remains statistically indistinguishable from no effect ($OR = 1.05$ per tier, $p = 0.77$). The two predictors

are not proxies for one another: budget-line status is close to evenly split across all five priority tiers in our sample, so the panel is not simply ranking already-funded pitches more highly to begin with.

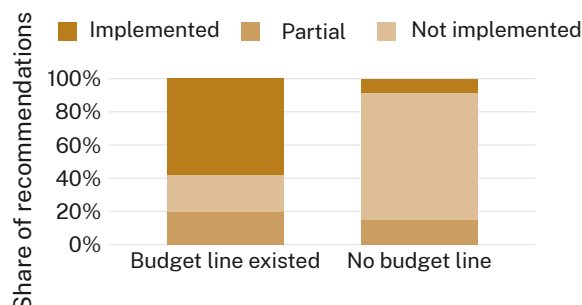


Figure 2: Implementation outcome for capstone recommendations, by whether a matching budget line existed at pitch time. 78% of recommendations pitched against an existing line saw some implementation, against 24% without one.

The ablation changes nothing. Figure 3 plots the any-implementation rate across all six cohorts, separately for budget-line and no-budget-line recommendations, with the Budget Literacy module’s introduction falling between the third and fourth cohorts. Both lines run essentially flat across the full window; the gap between them is as wide in the three cohorts after the module as in the three before it (OR = 12.4 post-module versus OR = 11.2 pre-module; budget-by-era interaction $p = 0.84$, n.s.). The tier-by-era interaction is likewise null ($p = 0.88$). We retain the module in the program on the strength of other outcomes it was designed for; on the present evidence, it has not changed how strongly a pre-existing budget line predicts what happens to a recommendation, only, perhaps, how often students find one to pitch against.

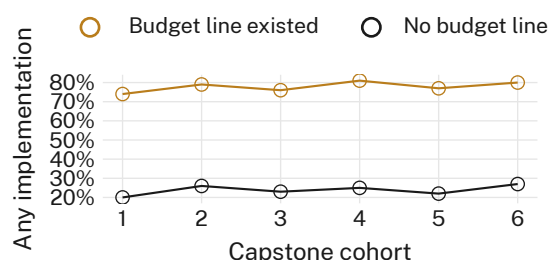


Figure 3: Any-implementation rate across six capstone cohorts, by budget-line status. A Budget Literacy module was introduced ahead of Cohort 4; the gap between the two lines is unchanged before and after.

Discussion

Taken together, the results suggest the capstone panel’s priority tier and the sponsoring unit’s implementation decision are answering different questions. The panel is well placed to judge a recommendation’s coherence, ambition, and fit with the School’s stated priorities inside a forty-minute pitch; it is poorly placed to judge whether the receiving unit has, at that moment, an appropriations pathway the recommendation can travel down without competing against everything else the unit might fund instead. Panels reviewing proposals under comparable time pressure elsewhere have been found similarly limited in their ability to predict downstream outcomes from a point-in-time score [15], [16], which suggests the pattern observed here may not be specific to this program’s rubric or panels. A structural reading, consistent with classical accounts of incremental budgeting, is that a recommendation pitched against an existing line is riding a budget cycle that was already in motion, while a recommendation with no matching line is asking a unit to open a new one, a much higher bar regardless of how urgently the panel judged the underlying problem [13], [14]. We would not want to overstate the generality of a single program’s six cohorts, but the consistency of the pattern before and after a curriculum change aimed squarely at the budget-line mechanism is, we think, some evidence that the effect is not an artefact of any one cohort’s panel composition.

Limitations

Our implementation outcomes are self-reported by alumni rather than independently verified against the sponsoring units’ own records, though the eighteen-month minimum follow-up window and the sharpness of the budget-line contrast make a purely retrospective reporting bias an implausible sole explanation for a pattern this large. Six cohorts and 151 respondents is a modest base for an interaction test, though the near-identical pre- and post-module estimates suggest the null interaction is not simply underpowered. Finally, our coding of “matching budget line” draws on administrators’ contemporaneous reading of each unit’s published budget, not on the unit’s own account of its funding intentions at pitch time, though this if anything biases toward understating rather than overstating the effect we report.

Conclusion

We tested the assumption embedded in the Master of Priority Studies capstone panel's own scoring instrument — that a higher priority tier marks a recommendation more likely to be implemented — against six cohorts of alumni-reported outcomes, and found no reliable support for it. What predicts implementation, overwhelmingly, is whether the sponsoring unit already carried a matching budget line at pitch time, a relationship a curriculum change aimed at the mechanism did not alter in size. Future work might test whether the same pattern holds in the School of Continuous Improvement's comparably structured capstone format, or whether disclosing budget-line status to the panel changes how it scores a pitch in the first place; we would welcome both.

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